REPORT - MILESTONE #1

TEAM MERAKI

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SECTION 1.0 / INTRODUCTION

Students enrolled in the Global Business and Digital Arts program (GBDA) at the University of Waterloo know first hand the issue of navigating around Stratford, be it during your lunch break, or trying to find a permanent residence there for upper years. While the GBDA orientation does include a component in Stratford that sends the students through the immediate surrounding area to the campus, it can be hard to get your bearings for a new town in just a short 40 minute walking tour. With the upcoming changes to the program curriculum, students will be moving to Stratford full time as early as their second year, meaning the problem of finding housing in Stratford will be amplified as increasingly larger class sizes will be moving into Stratford more and more frequently. While this may prove to cause some difficulties, it will also have the potential to create a strong community of GBDA students within Stratford.

It is for this reason that *TEAM MERAKI* has chosen to create a phone application called *UW Rencana* which is designed to connect students around Stratford. This application will allow GBDA students to find affordable shared housing with fellow GBDA students. The application will contain a main news stream of recent reviews and posts as well as the option to filter posts by reviews for each specific different available houses and apartments containing miscellaneous experiences with various landlords that students have had.

An application that is totally student run as such will foster a good community between students enrolled in Global Business and Digital Arts who are living, commuting to, and looking for housing in Stratford.

SECTION 2.0 / USER NEEDS

The following section will focus on what problems real potential users of the UW Rencana application may face. It consists of five interviews with five different individuals enrolled in the Global Business and Digital Arts program at the University of Waterloo. Data drawn from the interviews has been typed up into a summary, paragraph form, to present it in the best and most understandable way possible. The script contains ten questions that were written with the intention to best determine GBDA students' current situation, in relation to housing, as well as what concerns or issues they may have.

2.1 INTERVIEW SCRIPT

1. Are you interested in moving to Stratford permanently for the third and fourth years of your program, or would you prefer to commute (or are you undecided)?
2. Where do you currently live - on campus, off campus housing, or at home, and what has been your experience with you current living conditions?
3. Would you prefer to live in a residence that is associated with the school or live off-campus?
4. What housing style would you prefer, if any? (eg. apartment, house, etc.)
5. Do you plan on moving up to Stratford or are you going to commute?
6. Do you have a set of potential roommates for upcoming university years?
7. What are some of the most important things that you would look for when searching for a place to live?
8. What are qualities/traits that you would look for when searching for roommates?
9. What concerns do you have with the process of finding housing for future years at Waterloo, if any?
10. Do you feel like the University of Waterloo should make a more involved effort to help students find off campus housing, if they need it?

2.2 PARTICIPANTS

Interviews were conducted in person with five different individuals, all of whom have different backgrounds and experiences. All those interviewed have direct relations to the Global Business and Digital Arts program at the University of Waterloo. The interview is specifically aimed towards those students who are in the early years of the GBDA program to where they are going to start thinking about housing in their future years. The participants below will provide us with their opinions on what they think about their current housing situation as well as any concerns that they have at the moment when it comes to roommates, locations, etc.

2.2.1 INTERVIEW (i) - MICHELLE LEE

Michelle Lee is a first year Global Business and Digital Arts student who came from Seoul, Korea. Michelle currently lives in Columbia Lake Village (CLV) along with three other roommates that she met from Facebook a few months before. After speaking to them frequently online via Messenger and Skype, they were able to connect and decided that they would love to live together for their first year of university. CLV can be considered far from people since it's on the other side of campus from University Waterloo Place (UWP). However, Michelle has enjoyed CLV because it's located in a convenient area where the school closeby as well as a grocery store which she appreciates. Her residence is a townhouse with two floors with a living room, a kitchen, a dining area, as well as 4 bedrooms and one washroom.

In Korea, Michelle lived in an apartment with her family. Out of all of the housing styles available, she prefers to live in an apartment mainly because she feels that it's safer than a house at her age. She prefers having people close and being able to knock on their doors easily and she likes when apartments have gyms. As a first year GBDA student going up to Stratford weekly, she gets at least an hour during her break and is able to look around in the area. At the beginning of the year, living up on the Stratford made most sense to her considering her classes would be there for her final years. However, being up there every Friday, looking at the area, she is no longer interested because it doesn't seem to fit her vibe. She finds the pricing of food in Stratford is expensive and nothing has appealed to her. Therefore, Michelle will be commuting to Stratford for her classes and looking for apartments in the Waterloo area, near the main campus.

After her first year is over and she has to go back home to Korea, Michelle is going to start looking for housing options. She is already getting information from upper-year students and has noticed that there are many apartment buildings near UWP. A main concern that she has with the process is finding the right place in terms of her pricing options and knowing what exactly she wants. She has never looked for housing by herself so she's new to the process. Michelle mentioned that she was nervous about landlords pressuring her into signing forms that she's not 100% sure about - anything that surrounds around money worries her.

Michelle describes her ideal roommate as someone who has respect for both living spaces and knowing how to clean after themselves. Before she moved in with her current roommates, she had an idea about how they were as in their character but didn't know them that well. In the future, she would love to move in with friends that she knows that she's compatible with in terms of their lifestyle. Two months into first year, she already has ideas on who she would like to room with in her final years and she's beyond excited.

In general, she believes that it'd be a good idea for the University of Waterloo to inform students about their options when it comes to off-campus housing. There are many students looking like herself who aren't interested in the upper-year residences because there isn't much to offer. By having events or meetings where students could attend to find out about more information and perhaps get advice from other students would benefit many.

2.2.2 INTERVIEW (ii) - RONAN HICKEY

Our second interviewee is Ronan Hickey, a first year Global Business and Digital Arts student who came from Milton, Ontario. He was an ideal choice as he is GBDA student and is interested in moving to stratford within the coming years. His first experience living outside of home was within the university on-campus residence of University Waterloo Place. University Waterloo Place or UWP was his first choice, as he chose to be in the GBDA programs living and learning community. Living and learning is a program offered at the University of Waterloo; it is a program which rooms students of the same program together, as well as giving them an upper year peer leader, who will help them with program. His actual living accommodations consist of a washroom, three rooms, and a small kitchen. His experience as residence has been overall enjoyable, although a little hectic. The process of moving in for the first time wasn't the smoothest, but that was the biggest problem. Other than that he hasn't experienced any other major problems. Additionally he said he has found real value within the living and learning community, going so far as to say "it was one of the best decisions I have ever made". He communicates with his peer mentor extensively, and believes he has "made a life long friend".

In the future he is seriously considering living off campus, even though he enjoys his current living situation, he would be interested in more freedom with choices. He has began searching for residences for next year and is amazed by the variety of what is offered. In the future he is thinking of looking for a house, as the idea of an apartment doesn't really appeal to him, due to his liking for more personal space.

He is thinking of moving to stratford in later years, as it makes the most sense for him, having all his classes be at the satellite campus. The two most important factors in considering a residence to Ronan is size and location. He prefers his own space, and being located near eateries as well as public transit as to make traversing the town easier are both extremely important factors. As for roommates, he already has a couple in mind, but when considering new ones the only factor that really influences his decision is whether or not he gets along with them. He adds "not being complete slobs is a huge plus, I don't want to be featured on A&E's Hoarders". His one concern with moving forward, is availability. The process of finding a house that both fits his needs and is available, worries him, as he is not sure that it is a possibility.

Finally he vehemently believes the University of Waterloo should increase its effort in helping students with housing. He believes that housing is a major concern for most if not all university students, and due to that significantly more resources should be allocated in the pursuit of helping students. Personally unready for the upcoming issue, he wishes there was something in place right now he could look to help him with the future problem.

2.2.3 INTERVIEW (iii) - MADALAYNE ROCKARTS

Our next interviewee Madalayne Rockarts, is a first year student at the University of Waterloo, enrolled within the Global Business and Digital Arts program. She current resides at Mackenzie King Village, also known as MKV. MKV is a suite style residence, with four residents per suite. Each suite is equipped with four bedrooms, two washrooms, a kitchen and a living room. Madalayne so far has loved her experience at MKV. She finds actually having a kitchen a good option as she has more diversity with food, cooking some meals, and choosing to visit a variety of cafeterias when not up to the task. She finds MKV has the perfect balance between community and personal space; she enjoys having her own sectioned off room but also appreciates the fact that her roommates are less than two steps away.

Madalayne is planning on living off campus in a house the next couple of years. Some factors that heavily influence her decision when choosing an accommodation would be, parking spots, air conditioning, kitchen space, as well as location. Location to her is probably the biggest factor, as she is considering not moving to stratford for later years, instead opting to commute. Her reason for this is being the fact that she already has her roommates picked out, and two of those potential future roommates do not actually go to the University of Waterloo, instead are enrolled within Wilfrid Laurier University. Her only requirements for these roommates are friendly attitude, cleanliness as well as having some similar interests.

Since she is not moving to Stratford in later years, Madalayne is in a bit of a pickle when it comes to third and fourth year. To circumvent this issue Madalayne has bought her own car, which she will use to commute to and fro the Stratford campus.

Madalaynes has many concerns when it's comes to future accommodation. The first of these being housing prices. As the years progress, she knows the prices for housing are only going to increase and budgeting is going to be a real issue for her. Additionally another issue is finding something that everyone likes. Finding a home with just one person is difficult, but now multiply tension by five and you've got Madalayne's situation. She has just begun the search and already feels "extremely stressed and frustrated by everyone's unique opinions and ideas".

Finally Madalayne is a strong believer in the idea that the University of Waterloo needs to play more of a role in future student housing. She states "As a student of Waterloo, I feel unready to tackle housing market as it is my first time and I am inexperienced. Any sort of guidance or help would be extremely helpful and welcome". Additionally she believes that her situation is not unique, and that countless other waterloo students face the same problem and would being extremely receptive to any sort of housing help that the university provided.

2.2.4 INTERVIEW (iv) - ADAM CODE

Adam is a first year student who is currently living in Columbia Lake Village South, an on-residence living area for undergrads that is consisted of townhouses. Within the residence, there are two floors; a kitchen and living room on the bottom floor and bedrooms and a bathroom on the second floor. Initially, University of Waterloo Place was the first residence he had in mind but he ended up getting selected for CLV instead, which is a result that he is more than happy with. He enjoys the spaciousness of the townhouse and the surrounding environment, because he is a person who values his space and time alone. He also considers cooking an important hobby of his, and the kitchen downstairs allows him to do just that whenever he pleases.

In third and fourth year, Adam would rather commute to stratford. He has reviewed the living options there and does not like the places which he has seen, and would much rather have the convenience of living on-campus and closer to all the facilities and resources. Even though there are only off-campus living residences at Stratford, if Waterloo decided to open Waterloo-only residences, he would still be opposed to the idea because he does not want to be bounded by a contract to the school in which he could not cancel at any given time; he likes the flexibility. When selecting housing options, he would most likely want to live in a townhouse style again because he has enjoyed it so much this year, but only wishes to live somewhere off-campus for the upcoming years.

When looking for a place to live, Adam has some general rules, but also a few specific quirks. He would definitely want his own room because as stated before, he values having his own space. Being in a place where he is able to be self-sufficient and not have to rely on things such as owning a vehicle to get around is also important to him, seeing as he is a very independent person. In a similar vein, he also would like to live in close proximity of grocery stores and public transportation, because of the convenience. Something more niche that he is searching for is a residence with a place to store larger personal belongings, such as musical instruments, because he has hobbies that involve objects that take up a lot of space.

Adam has already found three friends that he would want to share a living space with next year, but he does have specific traits and habits he would like to see in a roommate. He hopes that they would have similar living and cleaning habits so there are no disputes over cleanliness, as well as having similar interests, although that’s not the most important thing. He hopes that they are able to cook for themselves as well.

One thing that Adam worries about is sustainability for future students in regards to pricing; he worries that rent prices are only going to skyrocket and it would be out of many students’ budgets to live off-campus. However, he feels that the University already provides an ample amount of support for housing for students, and it is good enough for students who need guidance through this project.

2.2.5 INTERVIEW (v) - KAELI-ANN HENDRICKS

Kaeli-Ann Hendricks is a first year University of Waterloo student in the Global Business and Digital Arts program. She currently lives on campus in the Eby Hall residence, and has so far found it to be a good experience. When she chooses not to use the kitchen in her suite-style dorm, she has the option to go to the New Residence Building next door and use the cafeteria. As she is part of the Living Learning Community, she is surrounded with lots of friends from her program who are always available to hang out and help her with her studies, a perk she really enjoys so far. She does, however, say this can be restrictive, as she has very few friends from outside the program and sometimes she feels as if her friend group is very confined to students only in GBDA. Regardless, she is still very happy with her choice to live on campus first year, as it allows her access to friends, school facilities, and gives her the choice to opt into a meal plan. As her residence is on campus, she does feel like she's better able to access school events and activities and stay in the know.

While Kaeli has no real personal preference between living in an apartment style or a house style residence, if she had to choose she would choose an apartment; while she isn't opposed to social situations, she'd like prefers a relatively quiet accommodation and feels that if she lived in an apartment the chances of her roommates having larger numbers of people over at once, or parties, is far less. She has a few people in mind with whom she'd like to live with but has no real plans as of yet. She prefers roommates who are friendly and charismatic, but also organized and responsible.

For her third and fourth year in Stratford, Kaeli is still undecided on what she will do, housing wise. She'd like to be able to either live in Waterloo or Stratford with all her friends, however she also is considering living at home for her final two years. Her dad works in Stratford, and commutes there daily from London, Ontario, which is a most cost efficient choice for her. She hasn't yet given this situation enough thought to be able to answer comfortably.

When looking for a new place to live off campus next year, proximity is a big thing for her. Proximity to her friends, to the campus and to shopping areas are all things she would take into consideration, along with having a kitchen and utilities, and of course internet. The only fears she has in relation to finding new living quarters off campus is funding, financials, finding good roommates, and switching to a new location that may not necessarily have all her friends in one place, like her current residence building does. Kaeli feels like while she may not need help finding an off-campus house, that the university should provide more help for students who do.

2.3 AFFINITY DIAGRAMS

Preferred Living Conditions

Preferred Housing Types

APARTMENTS

"Apartments are quiet and decrease the chance of roommates having people over."

— KAELI

"Apartments are always surrounded by people making everyone feel safe and secure."

— MICHELLE

HOUSES/TOWNHOUSES

"Living in houses gives each individual their own space especially when they have their own interests such as music and/or art."

— MADALAYNE, ADAM, RONAN

Accommodative Services

UTILITIES

"Having a kitchen with utilities such as a fridge, stove, etc. is important."

— MICHELLE, KAELI

"Living in Canada, there should be air conditioning, heating, and furnaces available."

— MADALAYNE

PROXIMITY

" Being located near eateries as well as public transit as to make traversing the town easier would be convenient."

— ADAM, RONAN

Satisfaction with Efforts from UW

Informative Meetings/Events

"Speaking to upper-year students and getting advice from them gives students insight on what they should do when it comes to housing in the future."

— MICHELLE

"Didn't like that there wasn't many resources on campus in the pursuit of helping students considering housing is a major concern."

— RONAN

Concerns

"Many students are inexperienced with housing and financials such as budgeting, therefore any guidance is useful."

— MADALAYNE

"Landlords pressuring students into signing forms and people mooching off others."

— MICHELLE, ADAM

Commuting/Moving to Stratford

Commuting

"I plan on commuting to Stratford for the final two years of the program, as I don't enjoy the living options Stratford offers."

— ADAM

"I enjoy Waterloo more than Stratford, and I own a car which gives me the option to commute. "

— MADALAYNE

"I didn't really like Stratford as a town, and found the food options to be expensive, so I plan on commuting from Waterloo."

— MICHELLE

Moving

"Since all my classes will be held at the Stratford campus, it would make more sense for me to move down to Stratford in the later years of this program."

— RONAN

Undecided

"Potentially may live at home and commute to Stratford daily with my dad, since he works there, but have also strongly considered moving."

— KAELI

Current/Prospective Roommates

Needed Characteristics

"I want someone who is compatible with my lifestyle and someone that I know personally."

— MICHELLE

"Must have a friendly attitude, are cleanliness, charismatic, organized, and responsible."

— MADALAYNE, KAELI

"Someone who can cook…"

— ADAM

Concerns

"Having roommates means that we have to find something that everybody likes. That can lead to stress and lots of frustration."

— MADALAYNE

"Living with people who he ends up not getting along with - not being a slob is a huge plus."

— RONAN

SECTION 3.0 / PERSONAS & SCENARIOS

The following four personas and scenarios have been created with the intentions of imitating some of the likely problems that students, teaching assistants, and professors may face, and how the UW Reneca app will assist in resolving these issues. By mimicking some potential issues that Waterloo staff and students are challenged with, and comparing our thoughts to the interview answers we have collected, we are able to better gauge what functions of this app need to be more prominent and what features will better serve users.

3.1 PERSONA (i) - ALYSSA

Alyssa is a local student at the University of Waterloo living at home studying Global Business and Digital arts. On the side, she runs a highly successful blog on Tumblr where she gives teenagers tips about school and life in general.

If Alyssa could describe herself, it would be someone who never wants to waste time. She is usually working on tons of projects, even if it's just for fun, and continues to share them with people on the internet such as creating DIYs (do-it-yourself) activities. She often reviews books for her followers to read, gives advice to people in need, and is a huge saver on money.

ALYSSA'S SCENARIO (i)

For Alyssa's final years in the GBDA program, she needs to consider where she wants to live - either at home, on the Waterloo campus, or on the Stratford campus. The downside to living at home or on the Waterloo campus is that she'll have to commute every single day to Stratford for her classes. The only thing that she believes to be logical is just to live on residence in Stratford. The problem is.. where? The Stratford campus is relatively new and small so she has no idea on where she could live. Alyssa has also realized that if she lived in Stratford, she wouldn't have an idea on what she could do there. At least living at home or in Waterloo, she would be able to do things because she was familiar with the place. Considering that she is an arts student, she wants to be situated in a place where she feels most at home being able to create things and feel inspired everywhere she goes. Alyssa is struggling on what types of houses she is looking for as well as what neighbourhood is best suited for her. For someone who frequently gives life advices to her followers, she could really use some right now. Perhaps, she'll try and get in touch with upper-year GBDA students and ask for their opinions.

3.2 PERSONA (ii) - EVAN

Evan is a second year student enrolled in the Global Business and Digital Arts program at the University of Waterloo. He is a starting player on the University's soccer team and spends a lot of free time training and practicing, both individually and with the team. By consequence, he misses out on a lot of extracurricular events hosted by the GBDA program.

EVAN'S SCENARIO (ii)

Going into his third year, Evan will need to make the decision to either move to Stratford or stay in Waterloo and commute to the UW Stratford Campus for all his classes. As he doesn't have a car of his own, he has chosen to move. This brings on a set of problems for Evan; he'd like to remain on the Waterloo Soccer team, and while he can train on his own, he would need to commute back and forth between campuses to attend games and practices. His second issue, pertaining his move to Stratford, is that he knows few people in the GBDA program. A majority of his friends lie outside the program, and many of them are people on the soccer team, or involved in other athletics at Waterloo. Despite the small class sizes, Evan hasn't gotten to know his classmates yet, and the fact that he misses out on the GBDA events especially doesn't help his situation. Evan has no idea where to move to in Stratford, and doesn't know any other GBDA students to move in with. He has few friends within the program and doesn't even know where to begin to look for GBDA roommates in Stratford, especially preferably ones who would need to commute between Waterloo and Stratford as frequently as him, or anyone within the program involved in athletics. Evan has tried posting to the general arts Facebook page as well as the Facebook page specific to the GBDA program, however as the university year has picked up there is substantially less students active in those groups and he has not yet had any luck.

3.3 PERSONA (iii) - IBTESAM

Ibtesam is a third year GBDA student who has spent a year living in city of stratford, as he is now a fulltime student at the stratford campus. He is entrepreneurial down to his fingertips and is currently involved in a business prospect involving the start up incubator at stratford.

If Ibtesam had describe himself in three words it would be loud, passionate, and opinionated. He often has heated arguments with his large group of friends and/or large family, refusing to back down without some sort of concrete evidence. This has been the cause of entertainment for many times, but have also lead to some personal strife between him and those close to him.

IBTESAM'S SCENARIO (iii)

Going into his fourth year, Ibtesam will need to find new housing within Stratford, to further pursue his education as well continue working on his business project. The past year of living at Stratford, while proven to be a valuable opportunity, has also been the cause of certain conflicts. Ibtesam didn't get along well with his landlord, frequently complaining about the sub-optimal living conditions, while previous tenants had just meekly accepted them. Due to this he was constantly in some sort of argument with the landlord, creating an unenjoyable for the both of them. To circumvent this, this year he is going around and having meetings with potential landlords, but is struggling to balance that with planning for his business and preparing for the upcoming school year.

3.4 PERSONA (iv) - LELA

Lela is a second year GBDA student who has been living on residence at the University of Waterloo main campus for the first two years of her undergrad, in a single-room suite. Originally from Hamilton, it wasn't a particularly far move for her. She has mild epilepsy which she has been able to manage efficiently, since her parents moved to Waterloo with her in a nearby townhouse and have been able to help her manage her symptoms.

Lela would describe herself as shy, but not reserved; sometimes she is unable to participate in certain social activities due to her disability, but she still has managed to form a close-knit group of friends. She enjoys low-stress activities such as painting, graphic design, and origami. She has joined multiple different arts-related clubs at Waterloo and despite her sometimes limiting disability feels very welcomed and included in events.

LELA'S SCENARIO (iv)

Lela's parents have allowed her to make the 3rd-year move to Stratford to continue with her studies like she wanted, instead of carpooling. They are to stay nearby in Waterloo in case a problem arises, but ultimately have made the decision to let Lela live on her own with no legal guardian residing in the same town. However, because of her epilepsy she has had difficulty finding suitable accommodation for her needs. She requires a quiet neighbourhood, as well as roommates who would be understanding of her condition and be able to accommodate. Unfortunately, most of Lela's friends are not in GBDA, which leaves her with the problem of having to find roommates within her program.

Lela has tried to talk to her friends in the clubs she participates in to see if any of them know of any GBDA students who would be open to living with her despite her condition and requirements, talked to students in her GBDA classes, and has also approached upper-year members on the GBDA Society to see if they had any suggestions. So far she has come up empty handed with no potential roommates and is trying to avoid the possibility of potentially living alone in Stratford, for the sake of her epilepsy and keeping the cost of rent down and split between roommates.

SECTION 4.0 / KEY REQUIREMENTS

The following section outlines the key requirements for students:

1. Students should be able to filter housing by housing types.
    - By allowing students to filter by housing types we will facilitate the process of finding the housing-style they're searching for. This will cut down on time that would otherwise be spent scrolling through multiple listings and posts advertising a housing-style that the user is not interested in.

2. Students should be able to filter houses by proximity to campus (ie. 5km-7km, 7km-9km etc).
    - Filtering houses by distance will be of assistance to students who are okay with being further from campus and those who need to be closer to the main campus, be it because they don't have a car, have a disability, or any other given reason.

3. Students should be able to publicly post requests for roommates/houses/appartments to a board for others to see.
    - Publicly posting for houses will allow students to share where they're living, how many roommates they need, or what type of housing style they're interested in. This will be essentially in initially connecting GBDA students who are in the process of looking for housing.

4. Students should be able to communicate (private message).
    - Once students have found potential roommates or a potential house, private messaging within the app will be very beneficial in getting to know or setting up a meeting with your landlord, prospective roommate, etc. This will allow students to communicate on a more personal level after finding what they're looking for and is not only essential in relation to the functionality of the app, but also to building a strong community and friend groups within Stratford.

5. Students should be able to review/rate houses and landlords, and sort/filter them by said ratings.
    - By reviewing different residences and landlords students will be able to help each other out and collectively avoid bad houses and landlords.